
Democrats' missed opportunity on Trump's immigration cruelty

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On July 26 in Pennsylvania, House Democratic Leader Hakeem Jeffries introduced the party's Fighting for an Affordable America agenda to mark 100 days until November's midterm elections. The [plan](#), according to the Associated Press, calls for "restoring healthcare cuts, bringing the cost of living down and ending the war in Iran to beat Republicans and hold President [Donald Trump](#) accountable."

[Democrats](#) always want to run on kitchen table issues, and this time they have an opening you could drive the Titanic through. Even among Trump's most fervent followers, the war in Iran is [unusually unpopular](#); it's the first time I can ever remember Republicans not rallying around a war started by a GOP president. In fact, the party used to rally around so-called "Democrat wars" too, at least most of the time, even as they condemned them for being mistakes. Trump, though, seems to have broken that knee-jerk reaction, which, if it lasts, may end up being one of the only things he has done right, even if it was by accident.

After Trump and the GOP's anti-democracy turn, there are no Democrats — and vanishingly few independents — who are clamoring for a "return to normal," if anyone can even remember what that looks like.

"Holding Donald Trump accountable" is obviously a necessary goal, and we can only hope that if they take back the House, and perhaps the Senate, Democrats will spend the next two years hammering Republicans on corruption, malfeasance, criminality and incompetence, pounding as many nails into the MAGA coffin as possible in anticipation of a hard-fought 2028 campaign. After Trump and the GOP's anti-democracy turn, there are no Democrats — and vanishingly few independents — who are clamoring for a "return to normal," if anyone can even remember what that looks like.

As we get further into Trump's second term, the rise of the progressive left, generated at least in part by the desperate need for generational change, is bringing some longstanding issues to the surface. Younger Democrats aren't talking about politics in technocratic terms, as the party's politicians have been doing for the last 30 years, offering up 10-point economic plans and telling the public how they can work the system more efficiently. They see politics in largely moral terms, and they are ready to address some of the thorniest moral issues we face.

Oligarchy is at the top of the list, an issue that has animated the left since at least the Occupy Wall Street movement began in 2011. Fifteen years later, a global backlash against billionaires who have outsize influence over politics — and who do not pay their fair share — is taking shape.

The left also rejects America's global role as security guarantor, particularly in light of the tragedy taking place in Gaza, which has been aided and abetted by the U.S. government. The party's mainstream has [moved substantially in their direction](#), leading to an unprecedented [split in the House caucus](#) in July that saw over a hundred House members vote to cut off aid to Israel. Whether it was done out of genuine desire to end the blank check or simply to allow members a symbolic vote going into the midterms, it's clear that the intense opposition to Israel's actions have made a difference, despite the ongoing debate about the scope of the policy.

These moral issues are animating a significant faction of the party, and they are having an impact. But I find myself wondering why another moral issue, much closer to home and shocking almost beyond comprehension, isn't getting much play on the campaign trail.

We are witnessing a fascist crusade taking place on the streets of America every single day that has seen federal immigration officers shoot and kill [at least eight people](#) since January. Over the weekend, a Salvadoran immigrant being held at the [notorious Delaney Hall detention center](#) in New Jersey [died after experiencing a medical emergency](#), the second death the facility has seen since December.

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The treatment of immigrants of all statuses, and sometimes American citizens who happen to look "foreign," is an abomination. But aside from perfunctory nods to abolish Immigration and Customs Enforcement, it seems to have become background noise.

Masked federal agents are killing people with impunity. They are splitting up families without compunction, throwing people in camps and deporting them to countries they have never even visited. Now, with the permission of the MAGA-compliant Supreme Court, the Trump administration is in the process of deporting Haitians who have been here legally for decades by forcing them to leave immediately or wear an ankle bracelet in anticipation of being sent to a country which our own State Department says is too dangerous to visit. These are people who own property and businesses, and many of them have American-born children. They also happen to be Black.

This is not a popular policy. While most congressional Republicans still approve of Trump's immigration agenda, many of them aren't thrilled with the administration's deportation policy. According to [Strength in Numbers](#), most Americans are appalled and prefer a path to citizenship for non-criminals. Trump's cruel priorities clearly work for many rank-and-file Republicans, and this seems to have some timorous Democrats spooked. But if there has ever been an issue that the left should be screaming about every single day, it's this.

Many Americans are out in the streets protesting and putting themselves on the line. In fact, average voters may be more up in arms than Democratic politicians. If the progressive left wants to consolidate the party behind a more virtuous set of values, this is the issue that will rally the entire spectrum of ideologies. Jeffries and party leaders should move it to the very top of the agenda, and make Trump's abuses a rallying cry across the country.

The Democratic Party should not play politics with this; the president's abuses are happening right here on our own streets, in our own communities. It is the moral issue of our time.

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about Trump's mass deportations

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